ABITUR ENGLISH · LANGUAGE

Commas

Three rules – and where German is different

REMEMBER

English commas follow **meaning**, not grammar: a comma **before** the main clause, **around** extra information, **between** two main clauses.

The three rules

1 BEFORE	Something comes **before** the main clause → **comma** after it. a linking word, a phrase or a subordinate clause	*However, the camps are expensive.* *In the article, the author argues …* *When they return home, old habits come back.*
2 AROUND	**Extra information** in the sentence → **commas around** it. Test: you could put it in brackets.	*Ben Huang, who works in Seattle, moved back.* *Rachel Hughes, a journalist, argues …* *Critics, however, remain sceptical.*
3 BETWEEN	Two main clauses joined by **but, so, or** → **comma** before it. also between the items of a list	*The town is small, but it has fast internet.* *parents, teachers and psychologists*

NEVER: A COMMA ALONE BETWEEN TWO MAIN CLAUSES

× *The camps are popular, they are expensive.* × *The camps are popular, however, they are expensive.*

✓ *The camps are popular. However, they are expensive.* ✓ *The camps are popular, **but** they are expensive.*

German speakers, watch out!

In German, every subordinate clause gets a comma. In English, **a subordinate clause after the main clause gets none**:

NO COMMA BEFORE …	EXAMPLE
that (German: „…, dass“)	*The author claims that young people are moving back.*
to + infinitive („…, um zu“)	*Many parents decide to send their children away.*
what, why, how, whether, if	*It is unclear whether the camps really help.*
because, if, when, before … after the main clause	*Teenagers book places because they want a break.*
who, which, that with **necessary** information	*People who live in cities pay high rents.*
than	*Living there is cheaper than living in a city.*

Model paragraph

THE THREE RULES IN A TEXT

In her article,[1] Rachel Hughes,[2] a journalist,[2] argues that[ø] digital detox camps are becoming more and more popular. According to the author,[1] many parents who[ø] worry about their children's well-being book a place. Teenagers,[2] however,[2] also sign up themselves because[ø] they want a break from being available all the time. When they return home,[1] old habits often come back,[3] so critics doubt that[ø] the camps have a lasting effect.

[1] [2] [3] = comma, with its rule [ø] = comma in German, none in English

ALSO

Numbers: *1,500 people · 2.5 percent* (German: 1.500 · 2,5) Direct speech: *She says, "…"* Letters: *Dear Sarah,*

Practice: comma or no comma?

1. The author claims that young people are moving back to small towns.
2. In the article the author describes three reasons.
3. Ben Huang who works for a company in Seattle has moved to Millbrook.
4. People who live in cities pay much higher rents.
5. When the teenagers come back old habits return.
6. The camps are popular however they are very expensive.
7. Many parents book a camp because they are worried about their children.
8. The mayor is optimistic but critics are less sure.

→ Solution on the next page.

Solution

Commas in **bold**.

1	The author claims that young people are moving back to small towns.	ø no comma before *that*
2	In the article**,** the author describes three reasons.	1 comma after an introductory phrase
3	Ben Huang**,** who works for a company in Seattle**,** has moved to Millbrook.	2 extra information about Ben Huang
4	People who live in cities pay much higher rents.	ø necessary information: which people?
5	When the teenagers come back**,** old habits return.	1 subordinate clause before the main clause
6	The camps are popular**.** However**,** they are very expensive. *or* … popular**;** however**,** …	! never a comma alone between two main clauses
7	Many parents book a camp because they are worried about their children.	ø *because* after the main clause
8	The mayor is optimistic**,** but critics are less sure.	3 two main clauses joined by *but*